

Corporate Record Book & Compliance Binder

Permanent Records, Registers, Compliance Calendar, Launch Gates & IRS Preparation

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[[ORGANIZATION_NAME]]

Founding draft for board adoption after incorporation and Tennessee nonprofit counsel / tax-adviser review. Not legal or tax advice.

Control principle

The institution should be reconstructable from its records without depending on the founder's memory, private accounts, or personal possession of documents. Critical authority, money, complaints, and safeguarding systems require institutional custody and independent access.

Binder contents

- Corporate Record Book Tab Index
- Master Document Register
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- IRS Form 1023 Preparation Dossier
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- Tax-Exemption Evidence Index
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Corporate Record Book - Permanent Tab Index

Tab	Contents	Retention class
1	Filed Charter, amendments, Secretary of State acceptance	Permanent
2	Bylaws, variant schedule, amendments	Permanent
3	Incorporator actions and organizational meeting/consents	Permanent
4	Board/member minutes and written consents	Permanent governance record
5	Director/officer roster, terms, acceptances	Permanent + historical
6	Founder Covenant and Board Reserved Powers	Permanent while governing + historical
7	Committee charters, rosters, minutes	Governance retention schedule
8	Conflict/independence disclosures and related-party records	Long-term; counsel/accountant schedule
9	EIN, IRS Form 1023/application, determination letters, tax correspondence	Permanent
10	Tennessee filings, annual reports, solicitation status	Permanent/long-term
11	Finance: budgets, statements, bank-control records, audits/reviews	Accounting retention schedule
12	Compensation approvals/comparability files	Long-term/permanent for insiders
13	Insurance policies/claims	Long-term; claims permanently indexed
14	Safeguarding governance/training records	Restricted, long-term per counsel/insurer
15	Complaint/investigation index (case files separately restricted)	Restricted; counsel-approved
16	Property, leases, major contracts, debt	Life of asset/contract + retention period
17	Intellectual property, names, domains, publications	Long-term
18	External integrity reviews and remediation	Permanent governance record
19	Annual integrity certifications/dashboard	Long-term/permanent summary
20	Dissolution/merger records if ever applicable	Permanent

Restricted files

Safeguarding, personnel, pastoral-care, whistleblower, medical, legal-privilege, and investigation files should not be stored in an unrestricted general board folder merely because the record book contains an index to them.

Master Document Register

Document ID	Title	Level	Owner	Version	Effective date	Review date	Public?	Supersedes	File location
GOV-CHARTER	Charter	Charter	Secretary	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	Event-driven	Yes	-	'[[...]]'
GOV-BYLAWS	Bylaws	Bylaws	Secretary	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	Annual	Yes	-	'[[...]]'
INT-FRAME	Institutional Integrity Framework	Entrenched schedule	Board	0.2	'[[...]]'	Annual	Yes	0.1	'[[...]]'
INT-RIGHTS	Participant Bill of Rights	Entrenched schedule	Board	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	Annual	Yes	-	'[[...]]'
INT-FOUND	Founder Covenant	Governance schedule	Governance Cmte	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	Annual cert	Yes	-	'[[...]]'
OPS-SAFE	Safeguarding Policy	Policy	Integrity Cmte	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	Annual	Yes/summary	-	'[[...]]'
OPS-COMP	Complaints / Whistleblower	SOP	Integrity Cmte	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	Annual	Yes	-	'[[...]]'
FIN-CONT	Financial Controls	SOP	Finance Cmte	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	Annual	Summary	-	'[[...]]'

Continue register for every controlled policy, SOP, form, and public notice.

Records Retention & Destruction Schedule - Governance Baseline

Important: This is a governance baseline, not a litigation/tax/insurance legal opinion. A litigation hold, investigation hold, safeguarding need, contract requirement, insurer requirement, grant condition, or legal rule overrides routine destruction.

Permanent

- Charter, amendments, bylaws, major governance schedules.
- Board/member formal actions and organizational records.
- EIN and IRS exemption application/determination materials.
- Annual external integrity review final reports and Board remediation summaries.
- Major property deeds, intellectual-property registrations, historical donor restrictions attached permanently to assets/endowments.

Long-term (minimum target 7 years unless counsel specifies longer)

- Financial statements, general ledger, bank statements/reconciliations, invoices/receipts, grant records, donation acknowledgments.
- Conflict disclosures, related-party and compensation approval files.
- Material contracts after expiration.
- Insurance policies and claim correspondence.

Personnel

Maintain personnel/payroll/benefit/eligibility records under applicable federal/state retention rules and counsel/HR guidance; do not use a one-size-fits-all destruction date.

Safeguarding / abuse / serious misconduct

Do not routinely destroy serious safeguarding, abuse, retaliation, or investigation records on a short schedule. Use restricted access and counsel/insurer-approved retention, considering delayed reporting, statutes of limitation, survivor interests, and institutional accountability.

Destruction controls

- scheduled and documented;
- suspended immediately by legal/investigation hold;
- secure destruction appropriate to sensitivity;
- no selective destruction after a complaint, audit, subpoena, anticipated dispute, or request for evidence.

Board / Member Action Register

Action ID	Date	Body	Meeting or consent	Matter	Vote	Conflicts/ recusals	Exhibit links	Follow-up owner	Closed?
`B-2026-001`	`[[...]]`	Board	Organizational meeting	Adopt bylaws	`[[...]]`	`[[...]]`	`[[...]]`	Secretary	`[[...]]`

Use sequential immutable identifiers. Corrections should be documented by later corrective action or amended minutes, not silent deletion of the historical record.

Director and Officer Register

Person	Role	Start	End	Election/ appointmen t authority	Independen t?	Conflict form current?	Covenant/ certification	Notes
'[[...]]'	Director	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[resolution]]'	'[[Y/N]]'	'[[Y/N]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'

Maintain historical entries; do not overwrite former service dates when personnel changes occur.

Authority, Credentials & Access Register

System/ account	Custodian	Authorized users	Approval authority	MFA?	Last access review	Removal SLA	Notes
Bank	Treasurer	'[[...]]'	Board/Finance	Yes	'[[...]]'	Same day	'[[...]]'
Accounting	Finance lead	'[[...]]'	Treasurer	Yes	'[[...]]'	24h	'[[...]]'
Donor CRM	Development lead	'[[...]]'	Executive	Yes	'[[...]]'	24h	'[[...]]'
Complaint channel	Integrity chair/external provider	'[[...]]'	Integrity Cmte	Yes	'[[...]]'	Immediate	Management should not control senior- leader complaint channel
Domain/DNS	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	two-person recovery	Yes	'[[...]]'	Same day	preserve recovery codes
Social media	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	communicatio ns policy	Yes	'[[...]]'	24h	organization- owned accounts

Founder personal credentials must not be the only recovery path for critical corporate systems.

Compliance Calendar - Baseline

Monthly

- Bank reconciliation prepared and independently reviewed.
- Restricted-fund reconciliation.
- Payroll/tax deposits and filings if employees exist.
- Complaint/safeguarding case-status review by authorized oversight.
- Access/offboarding review for personnel changes.

Quarterly

- Board financial packet and budget-to-actual.
- Institutional Integrity Dashboard.
- Conflict/related-party transaction review.
- Complaint, retaliation, safeguarding and policy-exception trend review.
- Board independence calculation.
- Public transparency page accuracy check.

Annually

- Tennessee Secretary of State annual report: generally due on/before first day of fourth month after fiscal year close, subject to current SOS rule.
- Director/officer conflict and independence disclosures.
- Leadership Integrity Certifications.
- Board self-assessment and committee charter review.
- Compensation review for insiders/senior leaders.
- Insurance renewal and abuse/safeguarding coverage review.
- Safeguarding training and screening refresh as policy/insurer requires.
- Donation-receipt year-end process and donor statements.
- Tennessee solicitation-registration/exemption status re-check.
- Tax filings/information returns applicable to actual classification and activities.
- Records-retention/destruction cycle after hold review.

Every three years or sooner

- External Institutional Integrity Review (first within 18 months of public launch, then at least every three years).

Event-driven

- Charter/bylaw changes.
- New location/property -> zoning, occupancy, property-tax exemption, insurance.
- Hiring -> payroll/workers' comp/employment compliance.
- Child/youth program -> full safeguarding activation before service.
- Communal housing -> separate housing/legal/safety controls before occupancy.
- Material unrelated business -> tax/accounting review.
- Major gift/restricted/endowment -> gift-acceptance review.
- Complaint against senior leader -> independent routing.

Public Launch Readiness Gate

A public website may exist before every operational program launches, but no program should claim readiness that the controls do not support.

Governance - must pass

- ☐ Charter filed and effective.
- ☐ Bylaws/variant schedule adopted.
- ☐ Initial board seated and independence documented.
- ☐ Founder Covenant signed if founder serves.
- ☐ Reserved Powers and conflict policies active.

Money - before accepting donations

- ☐ EIN and corporate bank account.
- ☐ Bookkeeping and restricted-fund system.
- ☐ Donation receipt/disclosure process.
- ☐ Tennessee charitable-solicitation status documented.
- ☐ Public statement does not falsely imply IRS determination before received.

People - before ordinary participation

- ☐ Participant Bill of Rights published.
- ☐ Normal + independent complaint channels active/tested.
- ☐ Privacy/confidentiality limits disclosed appropriately.
- ☐ Exit/non-retaliation process active.

Minors/vulnerable persons - before first program

- ☐ Safeguarding lead and independent escalation.
- ☐ Screening/background checks per policy.
- ☐ Training complete.
- ☐ Two-adult/observable environment rules.
- ☐ Mandatory-reporting quick card current.
- ☐ Insurance review complete.

Paid leadership - before first payment

- ☐ Role description.
- ☐ Conflict-free decision makers.
- ☐ Comparability data.
- ☐ Total compensation inventory.
- ☐ Advance approval/minutes.

Communal property/housing - before acquisition/occupancy

- ☐ Separate legal/financial analysis.
- ☐ Written occupancy/lease/license terms.
- ☐ No housing dependence conditioned on silence, religious obedience, or surrender of legal rights.
- ☐ Safety/zoning/insurance/accessibility review.

Public Transparency Register

Recommended public items unless legal/privacy considerations require a narrower publication:

Item	Public status	Owner	Last updated
Mission / beliefs summary	Public	Research/communications	'[...]'
Participant Bill of Rights	Public	Board	'[...]'
Charter / bylaws or governance summary	Public	Secretary	'[...]'
Board and senior leadership identities	Public	Secretary	'[...]'
Founder limitations / Founder Covenant	Public	Board	'[...]'
Complaint / whistleblower channels	Public	Integrity Cmte	'[...]'
Safeguarding statement/reporting route	Public	Safeguarding lead	'[...]'
Financial transparency report	Public annually	Finance Cmte	'[...]'
External integrity review summary + remediation	Public as appropriate	Board	'[...]'
Material doctrine-change records	Public where practicable	Doctrine/Research	'[...]'

Do not publish victim identities, confidential case detail, medical/personnel information, legal advice, donor information requiring privacy, or material whose publication would undermine safety/investigative integrity.

Board Annual Governance Cycle

Q1

- Annual disclosures and independence determinations.
- Prior-year financial close / outside accountant plan.
- Leadership Integrity Certifications.
- Compensation review before changes take effect.
- Annual transparency report approval.

Q2

- Safeguarding program audit and training status.
- Board skills/succession matrix.
- Policy/document hierarchy review.
- Donation/fundraising compliance review.

Q3

- Strategic/mission review separated from founder personality or succession.
- External integrity-review readiness / remediation status.
- Insurance renewal preparation.
- Technology/access-control review.

Q4

- Next-year budget and reserves.
- Committee effectiveness and Board self-assessment.
- Annual compliance calendar reset.
- Fiscal-year-end donor acknowledgment and records plan.

Every meeting

- conflicts/recusals;
- safeguarding/retaliation exceptions requiring Board knowledge;
- dashboard red flags;
- related-party activity;
- overdue remediation;
- closed executive session where necessary, without using executive session to conceal systemic misconduct.

IRS Form 1023 Preparation Dossier

Corporation: [[ORGANIZATION_NAME]]

This dossier is an evidence-gathering workbook for tax counsel/CPA and the Board. It is not the IRS form itself.

Part 1 - Legal organization

- Filed Charter and all amendments.
- Bylaws and member/nonmember schedule.
- EIN confirmation.
- Formation date and fiscal year.
- Directors/officers and relationships.

Part 2 - Narrative of activities

For each current/planned substantial activity describe:

1. What is the activity?
2. Who conducts it?
3. Where?
4. What percentage of time/resources?
5. How is it funded?
6. Who benefits?
7. Are fees charged?
8. How does it further religious/charitable/educational purposes?

Planned activity families:

- communal worship/gatherings;
- study/religious education;
- historical phenomenology / comparative religion research;
- publication and digital education;
- pastoral/spiritual care within ethical scope;
- charitable relief/community service;
- eventual intentional-community/housing activities, only after separate legal design;
- youth/family activities, only after safeguarding activation.

Part 3 - Compensation and insiders

Collect role descriptions, hours, compensation components, comparability data, conflicts, recusals, board approvals, housing/benefits, loans, leases, and family/vendor relationships.

Part 4 - Fundraising

Document website giving, recurring donations, grants, events, major gifts, restricted funds, donor benefits, fundraising contractors, and charitable-solicitation status.

Part 5 - Financial data

Prepare current-year actuals if any plus good-faith 3-5 year projections with assumptions. Separate contributions, program revenue, investment income, unrelated business, salaries, occupancy, grants, professional fees, technology, insurance, benevolence, and capital expenditures.

Part 6 - Public charity / church classification decision

If requesting church classification

Prepare Schedule A evidence addressing the IRS facts-and-circumstances characteristics: legal existence, creed/worship, ecclesiastical government, doctrine/discipline, history, congregation/membership, ministers, literature, established worship place(s), regular religious services, religious instruction, and any ministerial training. Not every characteristic is mandatory, but current IRS instructions generally expect an established congregation or other religious membership group.

If church facts are not yet mature

Do not manufacture facts. Consider with counsel whether the organization should initially request another public-charity classification based on expected public support and later seek church classification if/when the actual facts support it.

Part 7 - Governance integrity exhibits

Attach:

- Participant Bill of Rights;
- Founder Covenant;
- Board Reserved Powers;
- conflicts/compensation policy;
- safeguarding and complaint policies;
- dissolution language;
- related-party transaction files if any.

Board approval checkpoint

Before filing, Board minutes should identify: form/version used, requested classification, reviewed activity narrative, reviewed financials, disclosed insider relationships, counsel/CPA review, and authorized signer.

Church Classification Readiness Matrix

This is a **facts inventory**, not a score or guarantee. IRS instructions state there is no single definition of "church" and use facts and circumstances. Do not create artificial features solely to satisfy a checklist.

IRS characteristic / fact area	Current evidence	Planned evidence	Gap / question
Distinct legal existence	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Recognized creed / form of worship	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Definite ecclesiastical government	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Code of doctrine and discipline	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Distinct religious history	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Congregation / membership group	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Ministers serving congregation	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Minister selection/training	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Religious literature	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Established place(s) of worship	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Regular religious services	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Religious instruction for young	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'
Ministerial training schools/programs	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'	'[[...]]'

Integrity rule

Church classification must follow genuine institutional reality. The anti-coercion framework should not be weakened, and artificial exclusivity should not be created, merely to resemble historical church factors.

Tax-Exemption Evidence Index

Exhibit	Description	Source/date	Approved by	File link
A	Filed Charter	`[[...]]`	`[[...]]`	`[[...]]`
B	Bylaws	`[[...]]`	`[[...]]`	`[[...]]`
C	EIN confirmation	`[[...]]`	-	`[[...]]`
D	Activity narrative	`[[...]]`	Board	`[[...]]`
E	Financial projections	`[[...]]`	Board	`[[...]]`
F	Compensation/related-party file	`[[...]]`	Disinterested Board	`[[...]]`
G	Participant rights/integrity framework	`[[...]]`	Board	`[[...]]`
H	Church classification evidence or public-support analysis	`[[...]]`	Board/counsel	`[[...]]`
I	Form 1023 final submission PDF/Pay.gov confirmation	`[[...]]`	Authorized signer	`[[...]]`
J	IRS correspondence / determination	`[[...]]`	-	`[[...]]`

Secure Records Room / Repository Setup

Folder architecture

- 00 Permanent Corporate
- 10 Board & Committees
- 20 Tax & Regulatory
- 30 Finance & Banking
- 40 Development / Restricted Gifts
- 50 HR / Volunteers (restricted)
- 60 Safeguarding (highly restricted)
- 70 Complaints / Investigations (highly restricted)
- 80 Legal / Privilege (restricted to counsel-authorized)
- 90 Public Transparency
- 99 Archive / Superseded

Access rules

- least privilege;
- named accounts, no shared master password;
- MFA for sensitive systems;
- board/integrity committee independent access to records needed for oversight;
- founder/chief executive cannot be sole administrator of corporate records;
- immutable/exported copies of signed minutes/resolutions and filed documents;
- routine backup plus tested recovery;
- access log for safeguarding/complaint case repositories when technology permits.

Offboarding

Disable credentials promptly, recover corporate devices/keys, change shared secrets where unavoidable, preserve records, and document transfer of fiduciary materials.